

TEN QUESTIONS THE PM AVOIDED

Q. During the 2G spectrum allocation, a pittance was generated. But 3G generated Rs 73,000 crore. Do you think Telecom Minister A. Raja is in the clean?

A. I have discussed this issue with Mr Raja and he has told me that he implemented a policy which was in place since 2003.... The CVC has asked the CBI to look into it. If I come to know of any involvement at any level in corruption, we will take action.

Left unsaid: Does not want to antagonise the DMK.

Q. Have you finally decided in favour of a caste census?

A. I have made my statement in Parliament. We will take into account various views expressed. That process is on in the Cabinet.

Left unsaid: There is opposition within the Cabinet but wants to carry along new-found allies SP, RJD.

Q. Your government has been sitting on Afzal Guru's mercy petition for four years. Do you want India to be called a soft state?

A. Soft or hard state is a matter of perception. Perceptions can vary from person to person. Same person can have different perceptions at different times. There is the law of the land. It should be allowed to take its course.

Left unsaid: The Congress is delaying a decision on Afzal as it wants to woo the Muslim votebank.

Q. A section of the intelligentsia and even the Left have accused you of working on an American agenda.

A. I am working on an agenda that serves India to the best of my ability. It is for the people to judge.

Left unsaid: American agenda? This was the safest answer he could give.

Q. Are you confident of pushing the Nuclear Liability Bill through Parliament?

A. I am convinced that this Bill will have the support of all political parties interested in India's growth.

Left unsaid: Knows that the BJP and Left oppose it and he cannot get it passed without their support.

Q. Four states are going to polls soon. Will seat adjustments among UPA constituents impact the Government at the Centre?

A. I think we are too far away from the elections....

When the time comes, we will take appropriate decisions in all these matters.

Left unsaid: Regarding allies, it's best to direct the questions to Sonia Gandhi.

Q. Do you support creation of new states?

A. There is no agreement as of now to create new states. Telangana has been referred to a committee. Pending the receipt of that report, it is very difficult for me to offer any meaningful comment.

Left unsaid: With the Congress itself divided on Telangana, he cannot give a commitment.

Q. Any specific milestone that Pakistan should fulfil to reduce the trust deficit? How do you value our relationship with the US? Will we get access to Headley?

A. I have been assured by the highest in the US Administration that we will get access to Mr Headley.

Left unsaid: He ducked the first two questions as going into specifics could have boomeranged.

Q. In Parliament, the use of black money was discussed as well as the possible involvement of two of your ministers?

A. An investigation is on. Based on the findings, we will take effective action.

Left unsaid: Does not want to antagonise the NCP.

Q. What is the most important legacy issue for you in this tenure?

A. I am not bothered about it. I have a task to accomplish. It is for historians to pronounce judgements.

Left unsaid: His unstated dream is peace with Pakistan. But he is aware of the odds against him.